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Exploring Rubrics and AI

Introduction

In the evolving landscape of educational assessment, rubrics have long been considered essential tools that bridge the gap between subjective evaluation and objective measurement of student performance (Bean, 2011). As educational institutions increasingly embrace digital learning environments, the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in rubric development can represent a significant advancement in assessment methodology. This paper explores the fundamental principles of rubric design, examines various types of rubrics, and investigates how AI tools can enhance the creation and implementation of effective assessment instruments.

The importance of clear, consistent, and fair assessment cannot be overstated in educational contexts. Rubrics serve as scoring guides that provide transparent criteria for evaluating student performance, offering both educators and students a roadmap for understanding expectations and measuring achievement. Effective rubric development requires careful consideration of learning objectives, performance criteria, what different levels of performance look like, and the specific needs of both instructors and learners.

Understanding Rubrics

A rubric is fundamentally a scoring guide designed to evaluate student performance based on predetermined criteria. While traditional grading methods that may rely heavily on

subjective judgment, rubrics provide structured frameworks that promote consistency and transparency in assessment. The typical rubric structure, as shown in Figure 1, consists of rows representing different performance criteria and columns indicating various proficiency levels, creating a matrix that allows for systematic evaluation of complex tasks.

Figure 1: Parts of an analytic rubric



The primary purposes of rubrics extend far beyond simple grading mechanisms. First, rubrics provide clarity by establishing clear expectations for student work before assignments are submitted. This transparency allows students to understand exactly how their assignment will be evaluated and what constitutes excellence in each assessed area. Second, rubrics promote consistency in grading, particularly important in educational environments where multiple instructors may be evaluating similar assignments or where standardization across course sections is essential (Teaching Professor, 2012; Kuhs, Johnson, Agruso, & Monrad, 2001).

Furthermore, rubrics serve as powerful feedback tools, offering specific information about student strengths and areas requiring improvement. Rather than receiving a simple letter grade or numerical score, students can identify precisely which aspects of their work met expectations and which areas need development. Finally, rubrics function as learning tools, helping students understand performance expectations and providing guidance for improving their work quality over time (Allen & Tanner, 2006). Sydney Fulbright suggests that the use of rubrics could be considered a “defense against grade appeals” (2016).

Types of Rubrics

Holistic Rubrics

Holistic rubrics represent the most streamlined approach to performance assessment, evaluating overall student performance through comprehensive criteria descriptions that encompass all relevant aspects of the assignment. In holistic assessment, evaluators consider the student's work as a complete entity, assigning a single score that reflects the overall quality and effectiveness of the submission.

The strength of holistic rubrics lies in their efficiency and their ability to capture the overall view of student performance. For assignments where the interconnectedness of various elements is crucial, such as creative writing or comprehensive case study analyses, holistic rubrics can provide meaningful evaluation without fragmenting the assessment into discrete components. These rubrics work particularly well for simple tasks, essay questions, or situations where instructors need quick snapshots of overall performance. The evaluator might choose a performance level with an associated grade.

Table 1

Score	Criteria
90-100%	Exceptional - The paper demonstrates a sophisticated understanding of ethical concepts, theories, and their application. Arguments are clear, well-developed, and supported by insightful analysis and evidence. Ethical considerations are thoroughly explored, and the paper presents original insights or perspectives. Writing is exceptionally clear and free of errors.
80-89%	Proficient - The paper shows a strong understanding of ethical principles and their relevance to the topic. Arguments are well-presented and supported with relevant evidence and examples. Ethical implications are adequately addressed, showing a depth of thought and analysis. Writing is clear, organized, and largely error-free.
70-79%	Competent - The paper demonstrates a basic understanding of ethical concepts and their application to the topic. Arguments are generally clear and supported with relevant examples. Ethical considerations are addressed, though some aspects may lack depth or thorough exploration. Writing is generally clear but may contain occasional errors or inconsistencies.
60-69%	Basic - The paper exhibits a limited understanding of ethical principles or fails to effectively apply them to the topic. Arguments may be unclear or underdeveloped, lacking sufficient support or analysis. Ethical

Score	Criteria
	considerations are mentioned but not thoroughly examined. Writing may be unclear, disorganized, or contain frequent errors, hindering comprehension.

However, holistic rubrics present certain limitations. They provide less specific feedback to students about particular strengths and weaknesses, potentially limiting their value as learning tools. Additionally, the lack of detailed criteria can lead to inconsistency between evaluators, as different instructors may emphasize different aspects of the assignment when making holistic judgments (Bea, 2011; Kuhs, Johnson, Agruso, & Monrad, 2001; Wolcott, 2004).

Generic Rubrics

Generic rubrics offer a middle ground between holistic assessment and detailed analytical evaluation. These rubrics describe performance levels in general terms that can be applied across various assignments and contexts. The generic approach provides flexibility while maintaining some structure, making these rubrics particularly valuable in situations where students may be completing different tasks or demonstrating competencies through varied approaches.

Generic rubrics looks similar to a holistic rubric in that instead of a table format, one might see a selection of performance levels but there might be no associated grade. The grade might be aligned to a scale, such as in the text below, where a 5 is associated with an A, a 4

is associated with a B, a 3 is associated with a C, a 2 or a 1 is associated with a D, and a 0 is associated with an F.

> 5 - fully addresses the question fully and explores the issue thoughtfully; response is clear, unified, and coherent; response is fully developed and detailed; may have minor flaws
>
> 4 - clearly addresses the question and explores the issues; response is effectively organized; wording is well developed; supporting details are provided; may have occasional flaws
>
> 3 - response adequately addresses the question and explores the issues; shows clarity of thought by lacks complexity; wording is organized; wording is adequately developed with some detail; may have more frequent flaws
>
> 2 - response may neglect part of the question; response may be simplistic in thought; may demonstrate flaws in organization; may generalize ideas without supporting details; ideas may be undeveloped; may have patterns of error in language or mechanics
>
> 1 - response demonstrates serious problems in one or more areas specified in the previous criteria level; may have numerous errors in language or mechanics that interfere with meaning

0 - response does not attempt to discuss the topic; writing seems to be deliberately off-topic; there is little evidence of the ability to develop an organized response; may show extensive patterns of error in language and mechanics

The primary advantage of generic rubrics is their versatility. A single generic rubric can be used across multiple assignments, course sections, or even different courses, promoting consistency in evaluation standards while accommodating diverse assignment types. This consistency is particularly valuable in large educational programs where standardization is important for maintaining quality and comparability across different instructors and sections.

The limitation of generic rubrics lies in their lack of specificity. While they provide general guidance about performance expectations, they may not address the unique requirements or learning objectives of particular assignments. This generality can sometimes leave students uncertain about specific expectations for individual tasks (Kuhs, Johnson, Agruso, & Monrad, 2001; Bean, 2011).

Single Point Rubrics

Single point rubrics represent a minimalist approach to assessment, functioning essentially as detailed checklists that identify specific criteria without multiple performance levels. These rubrics list the standards or criteria that students should meet, with additional columns for documenting evidence of exceeding expectations and areas needing improvement. In the example below, there are no points associated with the rubric.

Table 2

Strengths (Evidence of exceeding standards)	**Criteria (standards to be observed)**	**Concerns (Areas that need improvement)**
	Content: • Demonstrates understanding of the topic • Presents insightful analysis • Provides comprehensive evidence and examples	
	Organization: • Well-structured introduction • Logical progression of ideas • Cohesive paragraphs • Effective transitions	
	Clarity & Grammar • Writing is clear, concise, and engaging • Effective language use • Virtually free of grammatical, punctuation, and spelling	

The appeal of single point rubrics lies in their simplicity and focus on feedback rather than scoring. By eliminating multiple performance levels, these rubrics reduce the complexity of the assessment process while maintaining clear criteria. This rubric encourages detailed, personalized feedback from instructors and can be particularly effective for formative assessment purposes (Greenberg, 2015).

However, single point rubrics may not provide sufficient differentiation for summative assessment purposes, particularly in contexts where grades must reflect varying levels of achievement. The absence of performance levels can also make it challenging to communicate expectations for different levels of mastery (Bean, 2011).

Analytic Rubrics

Analytic rubrics represent the most detailed and comprehensive approach to performance assessment. These rubrics evaluate multiple criteria separately, with each criterion assessed according to several performance levels. An analytical rubric is typically used to evaluate complex tasks where there are several different criteria to be judged. This approach allows for nuanced evaluation of complex assignments where different aspects of performance may vary significantly. One might use the example in Table 3 to evaluate how close an object comes to being a train, where observable characteristics are evaluated.

Table 3

Criteria	**Level 1** **(25 points)**	**Level 2** **(22 points)**	**Level 3** **(20 points)**	**Level 4** **(17 points)**
Physical characteristics	Has all key physical train components: locomotive, carriages/wagons, wheels, etc.	Has most key physical train components	Has some train-like physical characteristics but is missing major components.	Lacks most or all physical characteristics of a train.
Mobility	Can move under its own power along a fixed track or rails.	Can move along a fixed track or rails but requires external power source.	Can move but not along fixed rails or tracks.	Cannot move or is completely stationary.
Physical characteristics	Has all key physical train components: locomotive, carriages/wagons, wheels, etc.	Has most key physical train components	Has some train-like physical characteristics but is missing major components.	Lacks most or all physical characteristics of a train.

Criteria	**Level 1** **(25 points)**	**Level 2** **(22 points)**	**Level 3** **(20 points)**	**Level 4** **(17 points)**
Mobility	Can move under its own power along a fixed track or rails.	Can move along a fixed track or rails but requires external power source.	Can move but not along fixed rails or tracks.	Cannot move or is completely stationary.

The primary strength of analytic rubrics lies in their ability to provide detailed, specific feedback on multiple dimensions of student performance. Students can see precisely which aspects of their work excelled and which areas need improvement, making these rubrics powerful learning tools. For instructors, analytic rubrics promote consistency by providing clear descriptions of what constitutes different performance levels for each criterion. While analytical rubrics can promote consistency between instructors teaching the same course, consideration should be made to conduct calibration or norming meetings to discuss and align their understanding and application of aa rubric for consistent scoring.

Analytic rubrics are particularly effective for complex assignments involving multiple skills or competencies. They allow for weighted scoring, where different criteria can be assigned different point values based on their importance to the learning objectives. This flexibility

makes analytic rubrics suitable for sophisticated assessment tasks in advanced coursework (Kuhs, Johnson, Agruso, & Monrad, 2001; Bean, 2011).

Developing Effective Rubrics

Creating effective rubrics requires systematic planning and careful attention to both learning objectives and practical implementation considerations. The development process begins with identifying essential learning objectives and envisioning what exemplary performance looks like for the specific assignment or task.

Kuhs, Johnson, Agruso, & Monrad (2001) identified a set of steps to creating your rubric. An adaptation of their steps might include the following:

1. Identify the essential learning objectives, imagining what a perfect performance looks like.
2. Identify what will be assessed, the criteria, and those characteristics that will not be assessed. Don't have too many criteria – only use the most important to the learning experience.
3. Starting with what would be considered perfect, describe each performance level for each criterion. Consider that each description and each characteristic should be mutually exclusive. Describe as the lowest performance level what an unacceptable performance looks like.
4. Identify the scoring for each performance level. Just because a rubric has four criteria does not mean each criteria must be worth 25 points.
5. Develop a grid with your criteria in rows and performance levels in columns.

6. Ensure the instructions align and are consistent with the criteria.
7. Test the rubric. Consider having students use the rubric to conduct a peer assessment.

The first step involves clearly defining what will be assessed and, equally importantly, what will not be included in the evaluation. This boundary-setting ensures that rubrics remain focused on the most important learning outcomes rather than attempting to assess every possible aspect of student work. Effective rubrics measure what truly matters for student learning and development.

The next phase involves developing performance level descriptions, typically beginning with the highest level of performance and working downward. Each description should be mutually exclusive, meaning that achieving one performance level should not automatically guarantee achievement of another level. This independence between criteria ensures that students can excel in some areas while still developing in others. Allen and Tanner (2006) offer a few different performance level wording choices.

The number of criteria requires careful consideration. While comprehensive assessment might seem to demand numerous criteria, excessive detail can overwhelm both students and instructors. Effective rubrics focus on the most important aspects of the learning experience, typically including between three and six major criteria (Kuhs, Johnson, Agruso, & Monrad, 2001).

Weighting of criteria represents another crucial consideration. Not all aspects of an assignment need equal emphasis, and effective rubrics can assign different point values to

different criteria based on their importance to the learning objectives. However, the total points should always equal the desired maximum score for the assignment. Mertler (2000) offers a list of steps to designing the scoring for rubrics.

The alignment between assignment instructions and rubric criteria is essential for validity and fairness. Students should be able to see clear connections between what they are asked to do and how they will be evaluated. Inconsistencies between instructions and assessment criteria can lead to confusion and unfair evaluation.

Quality Considerations in Rubric Development

Effective rubric criteria must be specific, measurable, and clearly written. Vague language such as *adequate detail* or *clear writing* can lead to inconsistent interpretation and application. Instead, criteria should provide concrete descriptions that multiple evaluators could apply consistently.

Consider the difference between these criterion description statements: *Identifies a relevant problem or issue with adequate detail* versus *Clearly and precisely identifies a significant problem or issue*. While both may seem reasonable, the first contains undefined terms (relevant, adequate) that could be interpreted differently by different evaluators. The second, while not perfect, provides clearer guidance about the expected quality of problem identification.

The language used in performance level descriptions should be professional and constructive rather than judgmental. Some use levels aligned with scoring such as excellent for an A, good for a B, satisfactory for a C, needs improvement for a D, and

missing for an F. Terms like inadequate, incompetent, or weak can be demotivating for students. More constructive alternatives might include mastered, developing, emerging, approaching standards, or needs improvement.

Artificial Intelligence in Rubric Development

The integration of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in educational assessment represents a significant advancement in rubric development efficiency and quality. AI platforms such as Anthropic's Claude, OpenAI's ChatGPT, Google's Gemini, and specialized educational tools like MagicSchool can assist educators in creating initial rubric drafts that can then be refined and customized for specific contexts.

AI tools excel at generating structured, comprehensive rubrics based on assignment descriptions and learning objectives. They can quickly produce multiple performance levels for various criteria, saving educators significant time in the initial development phase. These tools can also suggest criteria that educators might not have considered, potentially improving the comprehensiveness of the assessment instrument.

Tools to consider that can help with rubric creation include Blackboard AI Design Assistant, Monsha.AI, Magic School AI, Anthropic's Claude, University of Florida's NaviGator Chat, Google's Gemini, Microsoft's Copilot, OpenAI's Chat GPT, and TCEA Rubric Generator. Each tool offers different features such as generating analytical rubrics based on assignment descriptions and typically include full descriptions for each criteria's performance level.

When using these tools, it is critical to form your prompt explaining what you want and providing context such as the type of rubric and assignment details. Some find adding the assignment's learning objectives to be helpful to the AI tool. Consider adding some of the following components within the prompt.

- Identify the type of rubric you wish, such as four-level analytical rubric. Using the term four-level specifies the performance level you expect to see. You can apply the performance level wording as part of your review of the results (e.g., mastered, developed, emerging, initial; excellent, good, needs improvement)
- Clearly describe the assignment or task for which the rubric is needed. This includes the topic, format, and any specific requirements, which can be turned into evaluation criteria: e.g., content, organization, grammar, analysis.

An example prompt might be as simple as "generate a four-level analytical rubric for the attached assignment" where the attachment contains the assignment instructions and the learning objectives, the specific learning outcomes or goals that the assignment is designed to achieve. You might even want to include instructions for the AI to include criteria that directly assess the learning objectives and that the AI should focus on describing the quality of performance at each level, ensuring the distinctions are clear and actionable.

In some cases you might find that instructing the AI on the role it should take along with the specific task can be helpful. For example, you might use

> You are an expert educator specializing in designing effective assessment rubrics. Your task is to create a four-level analytical rubric with detailed descriptors for evaluating a student assignment based on the attached learning objectives and instructions. Descriptors should describe the quality of the work at each level, moving from highest to lowest quality. Use student-friendly language throughout the rubric. Avoid vague descriptors; instead, provide concrete examples of what each performance level looks like in practice. The rubric should be fair and allow for diverse approaches to the assignment while still clearly differentiating between performance levels.

While this seems like a LOT of text, be aware that the more information you can provide to the AI, the more the AI can be responsive to your needs. Note that the need for a table format is not included as you can always place the result in your own table format and you may need to place the details in a specific format for your learning management tool anyway. The scoring is not requested in this example prompt as you can assign those after you look over the resulting criteria and descriptors. If certain criteria are more important than others, you can later determine that they should be weighted accordingly.

Many of the tools offer a feature indicated by a paperclip image or a plus sign that allows you to attach a separate file containing additional information to be considered by the AI when producing the results, Review the features of the tool you use so that you are aware of limitations of file size, word count, or number of files that can be attached. You might need to create a file specifically for each prompt that includes all of the information you want to be considered instead of attaching more than one file.

Once you submit the prompt with any associated files, the AI tool analyzes the provided input and generates a rubric with criteria, performance levels, and potential example descriptors.

It is critical that you review every word in your AI-generated rubric for accuracy, clarity, and alignment with the learning objectives. Keep in mind that the generic guidelines for creating a rubric, such as each criterion being mutually exclusive, must be considered manually. The AI may not be advanced enough to consider that guideline. In fact, consider adding *making each criterion mutually exclusive* within your prompt to see if you get better results. Edit the rubric to refine the language, adjust the scoring scale, add or remove criteria, and modify performance descriptors as needed.

To promote consistency between courses and terms, integrate the final rubric into your learning management system (LMS). Link the rubric from within the assignment instructions, recommending that students compare their work against the grading rubric before submitting the product. Making the assignment instructions and rubric available at the beginning of the term can help set clear expectations and guide their work throughout the term. While many students may wait until the last minute to submit work, making a major project or assignment's instructions available early in the term, and even in the syllabus, has been correlated with higher student success rates (Taylor, Kisby, & Reedy, 2024; Teaching Professor, 2012; Greenberg, 2015).

AI-generated rubrics should be viewed as starting points rather than finished products. Human expertise remains essential for ensuring that rubrics align with specific learning

objectives, institutional standards, and the unique context of particular courses or programs. Educators must review, modify, and validate AI-generated rubrics to ensure they meet their specific needs and maintain the quality standards necessary for fair and effective assessment.

Best Practices for Rubric Implementation

Successful rubric implementation extends beyond creation to include effective communication, training, and continuous improvement. Students should receive rubrics before beginning their assignments, allowing them to understand expectations and guide their work accordingly. This advance notice transforms rubrics from mere grading tools into learning supports.

Instructor training in rubric use is equally important, particularly in team-taught courses or programs where multiple educators will be using the same assessment instruments. Calibration exercises, where multiple instructors evaluate the same student work using the rubric, can help identify and resolve inconsistencies in application.

Remember that reviewing your rubric should be an iterative process. Regular review and revision of rubrics based on experience and student feedback ensures that these tools remain effective and relevant. Rubrics should evolve as courses develop and as educators gain experience with their implementation. Think about how students might interpret the rubric as compared with the assignment instructions and make adjustments to ensure it is clear and helpful. There are even holistic rubrics available on the internet that can be used

as guidelines to review your rubric (Mullinix, 2003). Consider reviewing your rubric each term or after each training cohort.

Challenges and Limitations

Despite their many advantages, rubrics present certain challenges and limitations that educators must acknowledge and address. The time investment required for developing quality rubrics can be substantial, particularly for complex assignments requiring detailed analytic rubrics. This initial investment, however, typically pays dividends through more efficient grading and clearer communication with students.

Another challenge involves the potential for rubrics to inadvertently limit creativity or unconventional approaches to assignments. When students focus too narrowly on meeting rubric criteria, they may miss opportunities for innovative thinking or creative problem-solving. Educators must balance structure with flexibility to maintain space for student creativity.

The risk of over-assessment also merits consideration. Not every assignment requires a detailed rubric, and the administrative burden of creating and maintaining numerous rubrics can become overwhelming. Strategic decisions about when and where to use rubrics are important for sustainable implementation.

Conclusion

Rubrics represent powerful tools for enhancing transparency, consistency, and effectiveness in educational assessment. From holistic evaluations that capture overall

performance to detailed analytic rubrics that provide comprehensive feedback on multiple criteria, these instruments serve multiple purposes in supporting both learning and evaluation.

The integration of artificial intelligence tools in rubric development offers exciting opportunities for improving efficiency and quality in assessment instrument creation. However, the fundamental principles of effective rubric design—clarity, alignment with learning objectives, appropriate specificity, and focus on meaningful criteria—remain as important as ever.

Even as AI functionality continue to evolve, rubrics will undoubtedly continue to play crucial roles in bridging the gap between teaching and learning, providing structured frameworks for evaluation while supporting student development and achievement. The key to successful rubric implementation lies in thoughtful development, appropriate use of available tools including AI assistance, and ongoing refinement based on experience and feedback.

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